

2

Esotericism in the Heart of the Renaissance and the Flames of the Baroque

I. A Discovery of Humanism: *Philosophia Perennis*

1. Re-emergence and Success of the *Corpus Hermeticum*

Toward 1450, in Florence, Cosimo de Medici entrusted Marsilio Ficino (1433–1499; section I, 3) to create a Platonic Academy, and about a decade later he asked him to translate, even before any of the works of Plato, the *Corpus Hermeticum* (CH, see [chapter 1](#), section I, 1) of which a certain number of treatises had just been discovered in Macedonia. Published in 1471, this Latin translation went through no less than twenty-five editions until 1641, to which those of other translations may be added. Common to many commentators of the period—starting with Ficino himself—was the assumption that these treatises, and their “author” Hermes Trismegistus, belonged to a very remote period, that of Moses. Many considered the treatises an adumbration of Christianity and thought they detected in them the presence of a teaching that would be an expression of a *philosophia perennis*, or “eternal philosophy,” in which this Hermes would have been one of the links in a chain of prestigious names.

In the Renaissance, this characteristic represents one of the ways in which several modern esoteric currents would orientate their obsessive quest for origins. Hence, the rediscovery of Alexandrian Hermetism contributed to give rise to a form of religious universalism previously espoused by Nicholas of Cusa ([chapter 1](#), section II, 2). As a result, Hermetism would subsequently flourish best in periods of tolerance (it was to find itself stifled in England; for example, during the Puritan period, under Edward VI and under Mary Tudor).

Among the main exegetes and editors of the *CH* in the sixteenth century, we find, besides the name of Ficino, those of Lodovico Lazzarelli (1447–1500; *Diffinitiones Asclepii*, 1482, *Crater Hermetis*, composed in 1492–1494; section III, 2); François Foix-Candale (1512–1594; *Pimander*, 1579), Hannibal Rossel (*Pymander*, 1585–1590), Symphorien Champier (1471–1538; *Liber de quadruplici vita*, 1507); Francesco Giorgi (1466–1540; *De Harmonia mundi*, 1525; *infra*, 2, and section III, 1), Heinrich Cornelius Agrippa (1486–1535; *De occulta philosophia*, 1533; *Oratio in praelectionem Trismesgisti*, 1535; section I, 2), Philippe du Plessis-Mornay (1549–1623; *De la vérité de la religion chrétienne*, 1582) and Francesco Patrizi (1529–1597). The purpose of the latter, like that of Giordano Bruno (1548–1600; section III, 1), was to restore true Christianity by incorporating the Hermetic writings and the Zoroastrian oracles with it (*Nova de universis philosophia*, 1591). This neo-Alexandrian Hermetism also tinges the work of John Dee (1527–1609; *Monas Hieroglyphica*, 1554; section III, 1).

In 1614, a famous Genevan philologist, Isaac Casaubon, demonstrated that the texts of the *CH* date from no earlier than the very first centuries of our era (let us mention, however, that other exegetes had noted this a few years before). Thus suspected of being much more recent than formerly believed, they found fewer admirers and commentators. Some Hermetists became aware of this discovery only little by little, while others ignored it deliberately. An English translation by John Everard (1650–1657) of the *CH* was published in 1650 and remained influential (it was based on Ficino's Latin translation). Robert Fludd (1574–1637) made the *CH* one of the foundations of his theosophy (*Utriusque cosmic historia*, 1617–1621; section III, 1), and Ralph Cudworth (*The True Intellectual System of the Universe*, 1678) used it to support his metaphysics. Athanasius Kircher, who studied its relationship with ancient Egyptian traditions (*Oedipus aegyptiacus* 1652–1654), contributed to reinforcing the wave of egyptophilia of modern times. Finally, this Hermetism also found its way into scientific discourses—thus, in Copernicus, who mentions the Trismegistus in his *De Revolutionibus* of 1543, in Johannes Kepler (*Harmonices Mundi*, 1619, section III, 1, 2)—and in the humanist Richard Burton (*Anatomy of Melancholy*, 1621).

2. Christian Kabbalah

The ancient Jewish Kabbalah had placed greater emphasis on theogony and cosmogony than on the history of salvation and messianism. This second aspect took precedence over the first after the diaspora consecutive to the decree of 1492 that expelled the Jews from Spain and entailed a cultural exodus especially directed toward Italy. Thus, Isaac Luria (1534–1572) orientated the reading of Kabbalah in this new direction that would later gain widespread acceptance in the Jewish tradition. This diaspora greatly contributed to make Jewish Kabbalah known and to stimulate the development of its reading in a

Christian sense—a reading that did not begin with the Florentine Giovanni Pico della Mirandola (1463–1494; section I, 3), but it really emerged with him. Pico did not attempt a Christian interpretation of Jewish Kabbalah but instead developed a hermeneutics of Christianity by using methods that the Jews employed to discover hidden truths in the revealed texts. In this, his “theses” (*Conclusiones*, introduced in 1486) mark the beginning of this current; in them he asserted that the Judaism of the Kabbalah is identifiable with Christianity and that “no science proves the divinity of Christ better than Kabbalah and magic.”

At this moment (1492–1494), Jacques Lefèvre d'Étaples wrote *De magia naturali*, in which he deals with magic and Kabbalah. Johannes Reuchlin wrote *De Verbo mirifico* (1494, followed by his *De arte cabbalistica* in 1517), and the converted Jew Paulus Ricius submitted his translations of Hebrew texts into Latin (*Porta lucis*, 1515) to those curious about arithmosophy, theosophical exegesis, and divine names. Kabbalah, magic, Hermetism, and alchemy are interwoven to some extent in the daring and celebrated synthesis (in fact, a vast compilation) of Heinrich Cornelius Agrippa (1486–1535; section I, 1), *De Occulta philosophia*, written in 1510 and published in 1533, which would remain one of the great “classics” of modern Western esotericism until today. Celebrated also in its period is the *De arcanis catholicae veritatis* (1518) of the Franciscan Pietro Galatino. Other Franciscans practiced a Christian Kabbalah, such as Jehan Thenaud, who wrote at the request of François I or especially Francesco Giorgio (or Zorzi; section I, 1), who dedicated his *De Harmonia mundi* (1525) to Clement VII. That book was translated into French (1578) under the title *De l'Harmonie du Monde*, by Guy Le Fèvre de La Boderie (section I, 1), and was followed in 1536 by Giorgio's *Problemata*.

The monumental work of Francesco Giorgio must not make us overlook the writings of Cardinal Aegidius of Viterbo, a genius of universal culture (*Libellus*, 1517; *Scechinah*, 1530). The most famous French representative of this current is Guillaume Postel (1510–1581), excluded from the Company of Jesus in 1545. In 1553, he gave an annotated translation of the *Zohar*, followed in 1548 by an *Interprétation du candélabre de Moïse*; many other books, including the first Latin translation of the *Sepher Yetzirah*, are to the credit of this prolific genius. Christian Kabbalah was implanted in England predominantly in the seventeenth century, with James Bonaventure Hepburn (*Virga aurea*, 1616) and Robert Fludd (*Summum Bonum*, 1629; section III, 1). Father Marin Mersenne attempted (*Observationes*, 1632), in refuting Francesco Giorgio, Fludd, and Postel, to combat what had almost become a fashion. Finally, the *Cabala denudata* (1677–1684), of Knorr von Rosenroth, contains a partial translation of the *Zohar* into Latin, abounds in theosophical considerations and texts, picks up the torch of Reuchlin, Postel and their like, and would serve as a standard reference to many subsequent kabbalizing theosophers.

3. *Homo Universalis*: Activity, Dignity, and Synthesis

Thanks to thinkers such as Pico and Ficino, the Renaissance, at its beginnings, discovered original horizons, like Hermetism and Jewish Kabbalah. Ways of stepping back from the cultural and spiritual fields inherited from the Middle Ages, *philosophia perennis* and Christian Kabbalah further expressed the need to practice a “concordance” of various traditions worldwide and favored the tendency to imagine correspondences at play on all levels of reality. This attitude was accompanied by an exaltation of human labor and human activities. Thus, in the case of Ficino, Hermetism and Platonism served to extol the greatness of humanity and to construct a cosmosophy (*Theologia platonica*, 1469–1474; *De vita coelitus comparanda*, 1489; section I, 1; section III, 1).

Pico, a multitalented polymath, intended to create a harmonious synthesis of Plato, Aristotle, and Christianity, but also to reinterpret the latter through “Kabbalah and magic” (section I, 2). Whereas Kabbalah relates to the “initial causes,” magic, which acts on the “second” or “intermediary causes”—for example, on the stars—brings together the natural and the religious, and places the branches of knowledge and of religion on a common trunk. However, despite the visionary cosmology that he presents in his *Heptaplus*, the very eclectic curiosities of Pico have little bearing on either Nature philosophy or mathematics. His spirited critique of deterministic astrology reminds individuals that they are free. Moreover, in his *Oratio de dignitate hominis* (1486), he declares that we are not only a microcosm reflecting a macrocosm, but also beings endowed with the faculty of making decisions about our destiny and about the place we are to occupy within the hierarchy of beings.

II. The Germanic Contribution: Nature Philosophy and Theosophy

1. Paracelsism

In the Germanic countries of the sixteenth century, Lutheranism tended to dampen the reception of Neoplatonism, neo-Alexandrian Hermetism, and Kabbalah. But this was compensated for by a “magical” vision of the world, very widespread in the Europe of those times, and notably by the appearance and the development of a Nature philosophy of which Theophrastus Bombastus von Hohenheim, known as Paracelsus (1493/1494–1541), is the most illustrious representative. This Swiss spent his life traveling through Europe, studying Nature, caring for the sick, and writing. Appointed professor at the Academy of Medicine of Basel in 1527, he did not remain there for long, having caused offense by his proposals of reform. Besides, he did not use Latin but German, and, to make it worse, he attacked the authority of the Ancients (like that of Galen), which he aimed to replace with “experience”

—in the sense of “practical experimentation.” In dying, he left a considerable body of work (*Volumen paramirum*, *Philosophia Sagax*, and many other titles) of which only a small part was published in his lifetime. Not until the publication of the Huser edition (1589) had most of his works got into print. While in the Neoplatonic tradition we pass from the first divine principle to matter through a series of degrees, Nature, according to Paracelsus, is founded directly on divine omnipotence. Nature is an epiphany. Moreover, Paracelsus is comparable to the Neoplatonists Plotinus and Proclus by his qualitative concept of time, “which flows in a thousand ways,” each individual thing possessing its own rhythm. Although not practicing alchemy, he conceived the universe in “chemical” terms; everything, including the stars, has been created “chemically” and hence continues to evolve—furthermore, Western alchemy initiated a turning point under his influence. An instrument of the knowledge of the world, of humanity, of the very Creator, it would increasingly become a totalizing vision. By the same token, this “science of Hermes” found itself connected as though organically to astrology, which Paracelsus did not conceive as a system of influences or physical determinations, but rather as a blueprint of universal interdependences, the stars finding themselves at least as much inside human beings as outside them. A principle of knowledge, an organ of our soul, called the “Light of Nature,” reveals the *magnalia Dei* or the correlations between humanity, the Earth, the stars, the metals, and the chemical elements. Just as our physical body takes nourishment from the elements, so our invisible sidereal body takes nourishment by letting the *Gestirn* (the spirit of the stars) act in it. The task not only of “Doctors” (physicians), but also of people in general, is to learn how to receive this “light of Nature” in themselves. Like Pico and Ficino (section I, 3), Paracelsus understood human existence in a dynamic perspective, as a task to accomplish. Hence, emphasis was placed on individual responsibility, whereas in the Middle Ages human beings instead felt immersed within the flow of a preordained community.

The influence of this thought was considerable. It radiated throughout several branches of knowledge, especially starting at the end of the century. The esoteric currents are not the only ones concerned; what would little by little become chemistry in the modern sense is, too, as is medicine—and this despite strong oppositions (e.g., that of Thomas Erastus, *Disputationes*, 1572–1573). Most of the great continuators of Paracelsus, notably Gérard Dorn (*Congeries Paracelsicae*, 1581; section II, 2; section III, 2), contributed to make him known in the second half of the sixteenth century and inherited from him his idea of the complementarities of the two “Books,” namely, the Bible and Nature. Among other very numerous names appearing in his wake are Oswald Croll (*Basilica chymica*, 1609) and Jan Baptista van Helmont (*Ortus medicinae*, 1648).

2. Jacob Boehme and the Theosophical Current

By the accent put on the “Light of Nature,” Paracelsism already heralds the great Christian theosophical current. It is again in Germany that the latter appeared. It is prefigured by such persons as Agrippa, Francesco Giorgio, and Guillaume Postel, whom we have already met; by Lambert Daneau (*Physice christiana*, 1575); by speculative alchemists such as Gérard Dorn (*Clavis totius philosophiae*, 1567; section II, 1; section III, 2); by Heinrich Khunrath whose *Amphithatrum Sapientiae Aeternae* (1595 and 1609) is illustrated by a series of plates become famous; and by Valentin Weigel (*Der Güldene Griff*, 1578; *Dialogus de Christianismo*, 1584), who strove to weave together the Rheno-Flemish mystical tradition and a concrete thought of a Paracelsian type (cf. also *infra*, 3, on Arndt).

Christian theosophy shares the characteristics enumerated above (introduction, section IV) with the other modern Western esoteric currents. It nevertheless possesses certain characteristics that, taken together, serve to specify its originality within this esoteric landscape and that, so it seems to us, come down to three.

1. *The God–Humanity–Nature triangle*: Theosophical speculation pertains simultaneously to God, the nature of God (notably the intradivine processes), Nature (external, intellectual, or material) and human beings (their origin, their place in the universe, and in the economy of salvation).
2. *Direct access to higher worlds* and this, by virtue of a “creative imagination” (introduction, section IV) that can lead to a specific experience, *Zentralschau* or “central vision.” The *Zentralschau*, a type of altered state of consciousness, is illuminative; it permits embracing in one stroke, as though intuitively, the totality of what constitutes the “triangle” mentioned above; the theosophers that do not have the direct experience themselves always refer to those of their predecessors who were gratified with it.
3. *The primacy of the mythical*: Theosophers practice a permanent and creative hermeneutic of the “texts of origin” (those of the Bible), which serve them as supports for meditation. They achieve this by privileging the mythical elements (that is to say, stories in images) of these texts (e.g., those that we find in *Genesis*, the vision of Ezekiel, and the *Apocalypse*).

The first great representative of the theosophical current properly speaking is Jacob Boehme (1575–1624). A shoemaker of Goerlitz, in Silesia, he had an experience of *Zentralschau* in 1610, triggered by the contemplation of sunlight on a pewter vessel. This determined his spiritual vocation and as an author. *Aurora* (1612), the first book that this illumination had inspired in him, circulated in manuscript and caused him trouble with the Protestant authorities. His following writings had the same effect. Only *Der Weg zu Christo* was printed during his lifetime, in 1624, and the first almost complete edition (by Johann Georg Gichtel, cf. *infra*) of his books came out in 1682. From this prolific work, one of the most impressive in German baroque prose, let us cite (only the titles are in Latin) *De Tribus Principiis* (1619), *De signatura rerum* (1621), *Mysterium Magnum* (1623).

Boehme is not a humanist and, if he is dependent on influences, it is those of Paracelsus, alchemy, and a little bit of Kabbalah. In contrast to a medieval and even Neoplatonic conception of God, he does not conceive of the latter as static but as the place of a passionate struggle of opposing principles. Before Being, there “was” the *Ungrund*—that is to say, the “fathomless” Godhead that ontologically ‘precedes’ Divinity (God) proper. It is not Reason but a principle, an obscure Will, which finds itself at the foundation of Being. Boehme therefore does not recognize as a supreme entity the *deitas* such as Meister Eckhart conceived it, and which escaped any becoming. Instead, he views it as a fire of a Heraclitean type, a principle that is never in *esse* but always *in fieri*, which “sees” in its living mirror, in the divine Wisdom or Sophia, the potential world. Thus, created by this vision, the divine image then desires, magically engenders, the temporal image.

In the West, sophiology, in other words, the discourses inspired by this character in the Old Testament (see *Book of Wisdom*, *Proverbs*, etc.), had not yet become the subject of so many speculations, but the *Amphitheatrum* of Khunrath, published in 1595 (cf. *supra*), could have set Boehme on this path. Sophia is almost everywhere present on the great spans of this baroque cathedral that is the work of the Silesian shoemaker. She finds herself associated there with the themes of the fall of Lucifer and of Adam, with the spiritual corporeity of the angels, with the idea that all exterior form is language or *Figur*, and with grandiose evocations of the seven *Quellgeister* or “source-spirits” structuring the relationships between God, humanity, and the universe.

This “prince of Christian theosophy,” as he has often been called, enjoyed a certain success in the general turmoil of seventeenth-century Germany. But in other countries, too, theosophy would continue to flourish, irrigated by the thought of Boehme, with Johann Georg Gichtel (1638–1710; *Theosophia practica*, published only in 1722; section III, 3), Gottfried Arnold (*Das Geheimniss der göttlichen Weissheit oder Sophia*, 1700; section III, I, 1), Pierre Poiret (*L'Économie divine ou Système universel*, 1687), Antoinette Bourignon (*Oeuvres* published by Poiret, 1679–1684), John Pordage (*Sophia*, 1675; *Theologia mystica*, 1683), Jane Leade (*A Fountain of Gardens*, 1700)—and many others. Besides theosophy properly speaking, various authors and currents were receptive to Boehme and to Paracelsus, whose teachings seemed to favor a union of faith and knowledge.

3. The First Rosy-Cross

The first Rosicrucian text appeared in 1614, at Cassel (Germany). It was an anonymous manifesto of thirty-eight pages in German, titled *Fama Fraternitatis* “of the praiseworthy order of the Rose Cross,” addressed to “all the scholars of Europe” (but this text had already circulated for about four years in manuscript form). We find in it a critique of the spiritual situation of Europe, accompanied by

considerations on a possible redemption owing not to the Churches but to a spiritual science in which heart and knowledge would find union. Added to hints of Christian Kabbalah and Pythagoreanism, as well as a strong stamp of Paracelsism, is the biography of a mythical character, C.R.C., a great traveler who would have sojourned in Arabia, in Egypt, and then returned home to Germany to found the said Fraternity there. One hundred and twenty years after his death, in 1604 according to this text, his tomb containing magical formulas and secrets of life would have been found.

In 1615, the *Fama Fraternitatis* was republished in Frankfurt with another text, also anonymous, the *Confessio Fraternitatis*, whose authors observe that the age has entered the sign of Mercury, the “Lord of the Word.” They suggest that they are about to reveal part of the Adamic language by means of which people can discover the hidden meanings of the Bible and, at the same time, of creation because the Scriptures are “the Compendium and the quintessence of the whole world.” The third text, *Chymische Hochzeit Christiani Rosencreutz Anno 1459* (The Chemical Wedding of Christian Rosenkreutz in the Year 1459), published in 1616 and also anonymous, is an initiatic novel whose hero, Christian Rosenkreutz, undertakes a journey in which the hierogamy of Christ and of His Church, of God with His creation, are described in alchemical metaphors. This fine baroque novel has never ceased to stimulate new works of exegesis.

The first two of these three texts were the work of several authors at this time of great crisis that led to the Thirty Years War. Among them were, in all likelihood, Tobias Hess (1568–1614) and Johann Valentin Andreae (1586–1654). Hess was known as a medical doctor. Andreae (1586–1654), who belonged to an important dynasty of Swabian Lutheranism, is the undisputed author of the novel published in 1616. He left at his death a rather considerable body of work. In his lifetime, he found himself prey to a great deal of harassment because the Protestant authorities strongly suspected him of being the source of the Rosicrucian myth that, with the publication of the two manifestoes (the *Fama* and the *Confessio*), enjoyed overwhelming success.

Indeed, a great many writings either favorable to the contents of these two texts or directed against them immediately appeared in various countries. We count more than two hundred of them between 1614 and 1620, and about nine hundred up to the beginning of the nineteenth century. Among the most important authors having immediately defended and spread the “Rosicrucian” ideas, were Robert Fludd (*Apologia* [Rosae Crucis], 1516; section III, 1), Theophilus Schweighart (*Speculum Sophicum Rhodo Stauroticum*, 1618), and Jan Amos Comenius (*Christianiae societatis imago*, 1620). With Comenius, the irenic project of Andreae, which did not go beyond Germany and the Lutheran confession, “took on planetary dimensions and heralded the humanitarianism of Freemasonry” (R. Edighoffer). In fact, the ideas sown by Comenius took shape in 1660 with the founding of the Royal Society of London (indeed the English,

like the Germans, then proved more receptive than did the French to the introduction of Rosicrucian ideas).

The Society with which we are dealing in the two manifestoes is only a literary myth, but we can probably consider that the multiplication of initiatic societies starting in the eighteenth century finds one of its direct origins there ([chapter 3](#), section III). Furthermore, the Rosicrucian current largely contributed to favor the interest of the period for speculations of a theosophical character related to Nature, in the Paracelsian wake. This interest was shared, notably, by Aegidius Gutman (*Offenbahrung göttlicher Majestät*; published in 1619, this work had circulated since its completion, probably as early as 1575); by Simon Studion (whose *Naometria* of the same period, although still unpublished, was also in circulation); and by Johann Arndt (1555–1621).

In his *Vier Bücher vom wahren Christenthum* (principally in the last of the four volumes, published in 1610), Arndt develops and specifies what, beginning with him, would be called—in his own terms—“mystical theology.” The latter was an attempt to integrate medieval mysticism, the neo-Paracelsian heritage, and alchemy, with theology—an integration possibly due, according to him, to a faculty attributed to the individual to achieve a “second birth,” understood as the acquisition of a new body in the elected soul. It might seem permissible to see in this mystical theology a subtle link between the Rosicrucian manifestoes and the *Chemical Wedding* of Andreae, but also one of the reasons for the vogue of the theosophical current.

III. Readings of the World and of Myths

1. *Philosophia Occulta*

From the end of the fifteenth century to that of the seventeenth, the currents hitherto mentioned all more or less belong to the so-called *philosophia occulta*, understood as a “magical” conception of the world where everything acts upon and reflects everything else analogically. Witchcraft and its spells, black magic, pacts with the Devil, and goety (*goetia*, invocation of angels or demons) are only very indirectly connected with these currents, but they represent like the dark side of this *philosophia occulta* and constitute an important sector of the *imaginaire* of those days.

Magia naturalis is a premodern form of natural science; it is the knowledge and the use of forces and occult virtues (powers) considered as “natural” because objectively present in nature (cf. e.g., *Magiae naturalis libri viginti*, 1589, of Giovanni Battista della Porta). It is hardly distinguishable from an experimental science still in its infancy and it often appears as a form of naturalism tainted with atheism. However, this ambiguous expression can also refer to a *magia* understood as an attempt to unify Nature

and religion. To this *magia* belongs white magic or theurgy, which uses names, rites, and incantations with a view to establishing a personal link with entities not belonging to the world of physical creation. The two aspects of *magia naturalis* (the naturalist type, and white magic) are sometimes combined; thus, in “celestial” or “astronomical” magic, the stars are considered from a double viewpoint: as much their physical and natural influence as their “will” (cf. e.g., *De Vita coelitus comparanda*, 1489, by Ficino; *De occulta philosophia*, 1533, by Agrippa; section I, 1).

To these very representative names of “occult philosophy” let us add six of the principle ones (Fludd, Paracelsus; a number of others, cited *supra*, are obviously connected with it). Johannes Trithemius (1462–1516), abbot of Spanheim, is the author of a *Steganographia* that remained unpublished until 1606, and his *De Septem Secundeis* (1522) treats of the seven angels or intelligences animating the celestial orbs and the history of the world. Jacques Gohory (*alias* Leo Suavius, 1520–1576), musicologist, neo-Paracelsian, has left notably a *De usu et mysteriis notarum liber* (1550). To invoke the angels, the Elizabethan magus John Dee (1527–1609; section I, 1) combined Kabbalistic operations with the angelic hierarchies of Pseudo-Dionysius (*A True and Faithful Relation*, published in 1659). The Dominican Tommaso Campanella (1568–1639) is one of the last great philosophers of the Renaissance in the Ficinian tradition (*De sensu rerum et magia*, 1620). To these names should be added, of course, those of Francis Bacon (1561–1626; *Novum Organum*, 1620; *Sylva silvarum*, 1627); and Giordano Bruno (1548–1600; section I, 1), a Copernican marked by Alexandrian Hermetism and champion of a religious irenicism. In his occult philosophy of Nature, Bruno makes little room for the angelic world; and it was not his books of magic (*Sigillus sigillorum*, 1583; *De Imaginum ... compositione*, 1591, etc.) that got him burned at the stake of the Inquisition, but rather his anti-Trinitarian and cosmological views (of an infinite universe, notably).

A celestial arithmetic and music is constant underpinning to these forms of “universal magic.” Henceforth, and more than ever, astrology would take on the role of “queen of sciences.” It lends itself well to this in its Paracelsian aspect, but in the seventeenth century, it also tended to assume a different one. The two famous theoreticians Placido Titi (*Physiomathematica*, 1650) and Jean-Baptiste Morin (*Astrologia Gallica*, 1661) aimed to tie it to the cosmologies of Aristotle and Ptolemy, at the very time when these cosmologies were definitively undermined by the discoveries in astronomy and by the new celestial mechanics. It nonetheless remains that in the sixteenth and the seventeenth centuries intermediary spirits, stars, and things of our Earth continued to “correspond” in the sense of interconnections that Ficino, for example, saw as occurring via the *spiritus mundi*, a vehicle of stellar influx. It is not the world of the medieval *Picatrix* that was changed; it is instead the role of humanity that was perceived differently, as less passive.

The main faculty—essentially “active”—that permits penetrating the world of correspondences is, as we have seen, the imagination—the *vis imaginativa*—supposed to produce effects on our own body as on the outside of the latter, at the same time as it is an instrument of knowledge, of *gnosis*. Connected to this idea was the famous “Art of memory” inherited from procedures of medieval mnemotechnique and inspired by Alexandrian Hermetism. It consists in making enter, in some manner, into our mind—into our *mens*—human history, Nature, and all available knowledge, by associating mental images with mythological and planetary referents (cf. especially Giulio Camillo, *L'idea del teatro*, 1550, and various writings of Bruno and Fludd).

The arithmology of the neo-Pythagorean tradition made its presence felt in this whole in a manner that was usually obvious. It was the subject of specific treatment by Josse Clichtove (*De mystica numerorum significationae*, 1513), a disciple of Lefèvre d'Étaples around whom the arithmosophers Charles de Bovelles and Germain de Ganay also worked—or by Petrus Bungus (*Numerorum mysteria*, 1588). It was present in the cosmology of Johannes Kepler himself (*Mysterium cosmographicum*, 1596; section I, 1), who was also an astrologer. Numbers and mathematics were for Robert Fludd (*Utriusque cosmic historia*, 1617–1619; section III, 3) a privileged tool enabling study of the entire structure of the visible and invisible universe in its unity. He associated them intimately with music, just as Francesco Giorgi (section I, 1, 2) before him and Fabio Paolini (*Hebdomades*, 1589), or again Michael Maier in his *Atalanta fugiens* (1618; section III, 3).

The sixteenth century also witnessed the appearance of historical figures that posterity would cloak with an aura of mystery. Thus, Michel de Nostre-Dame (*alias* Nostradamus, 1503–1566), who practiced theurgy and wrote “prognostications” in verses, which relate to future history (his *Centuries* and his *Prophecies* have gone through a great number of re-editions.) In addition, Georg Faust, who lived from 1480 to about 1540, would have signed a pact with the Devil. Faust's sulfurous adventure was recounted in a German *Volksbuch* printed in 1587 (it has inspired countless works of fiction). Let us note finally that, in the form of *dissertationes* and *disputationes*, the universities of the seventeenth century, in Germany perhaps still more than elsewhere, bear witness to a lively interest in the occult. Moreover, in Spain and in Portugal a strong Islamic stamp created fertile ground for interest in *philosophia occulta*. To wit, *De Medendis corporis malis* (1605), by Bravo Chamisso, a medical doctor from Louvain; and *Demonologia sive de magia*, (1623), by Francisco Torreblanca, a jurist from Cordova.

2. Alchemy: Science of Humanity, Nature, and Myths

Still at the beginning of the sixteenth century, the alchemical writings circulated mainly in manuscript form; thus, a treatise of Lodovico Lazzarelli (section I, 1), or the *De Auro* of Gianfrancesco Pico della

Mirandola (written in 1527, published in 1586). Among the most widely known of the printed publications are the poem *Chrisopoeia* (1515) by G. A. Augurello, *Ars transmutationis* (1518) by J. A. Pantheus, and *Coelum philosophorum* (1525) by Philip Ulstad. To these works are added several anthologies of various treatises, such as *De Alchemia* in 1541 (which contains the first printed version of the famous text *The Emerald Tablet*), or *Verae alchemiae ...* (1561) edited by Gulielmo Gratarolo.

Starting from the end of the century, an important part of alchemical literature fits into the Paracelsian wake and often appears as a proto-theosophy, as with Dorn and Khunrath (section II, 2). It further makes itself distinctly theosophizing in the case of Thomas Vaughan (*Magia adamica*, 1650). In England, Elias Ashmole, one of the founders of the Royal Society, contributed to its influence, and it was the purpose of the “Invisible College” of Samuel Hartlib to bring together all chemical and alchemical knowledge.

Besides this pansophic tendency, let us note three characteristic traits of seventeenth-century alchemy:

1. An interest in mythology, considered as a system of keys hiding the secrets of the Great Work under allegories (thus, in the case of Clovis Hesteau de Nuysement, *Traictez du vray Sel*, 1621; or Willem Mennens, *Aurei Velleris libri tres*, 1604). This tendency goes back to the High Middle Ages.

2. A taste for fine illustrations (*infra*, 3).

3. Editions of encyclopedias, anthologies, and sometimes voluminous compilations: *Theatrum Chemicum*, 1602 (edited by Eberhard Zetzner) several re-editions, including the one in six large volumes (1659–1661); *Theatrum Chemicum Britannicum*, introduced by Elias Ashmole, 1652; *Musaeum Hermeticum*, 1678; *Bibliotheca chemica curiosa*, edited by Jean-Jacques Manget (1702, 2 infol.).

Alchemy was patronized by German emperors (Rudolf II of Prague especially, but also Ferdinand II) and many princes, because they thought of gaining riches through the transmutations of metals. Some of the learned founders of modern science did not disdain it. Isaac Newton devoted a considerable time to it (most of the many alchemical writings that he has left date from the seven or eight years that followed the appearance of his *Principia* of 1686). Finally, we could not overemphasize that, in a general manner over the course of this long period, the alchemists clearly strove to do “scientific” work and not—contrary to what is too easily believed today—to oppose who knows what “official science” of their time.

3. A Hermetico-Emblematic Art

A hermeticizing art is present in Renaissance Italy. Either a character like the Trismegistus himself appears in the figures (thus, in 1488, on the pavement of the cathedral of Sienna), or zodiacal signs, mythical characters and hermetic symbols are associated to create frescoes or paintings (Borgia

apartments in the Vatican, the *Primavera* of Botticelli in 1478, etc). With the first plates of his *De Mundi aetatibus imagines* (1545–1573), the Portuguese Francesco de Holanda proved himself a brilliant precursor of Jacob Boehme and of William Blake.

From the end of the sixteenth century and for about thirty years, we see the flowering of many works in which the importance of the engravings is equal to or greater than that of the text itself. Mostly alchemical, the engravings are in the line of the emblematic tradition born with Andrea Alciati's *Emblemata* (1551). These include, for example, *Cabala* (1616) of Stephan Michelspacher, *Opus medicochymicus* and *Philosophia reformata* (1622) of J. D. Mylius, *De lapide philosophico* of Lampsprinck (1625), the anthology of Ashmole (*supra*, 2), the *Mutus liber* (1677, without text) or again the celebrated *Atalanta fugiens* (1618, section III, 1) of Michael Maier, in which each of the fifty emblematic plates is accompanied by a text and a musical score. Not essentially alchemical but instead theosophical are certain works that are admirably illustrated, such as the *Amphitheatrum Sapientiae Aeternae* (section II, 2; section III, 2) of Heinrich Khunrath, the *Utriusque Cosmi historia* (1617–1621) of Robert Fludd—or again the almost complete edition (1682) of Boehme's works, in Amsterdam, presented by Johann Georg Gichtel (section II, 2).

Literature, too, also maintained fruitful relationships with esotericism. The *Hypnerotomachia* (or *Dream of Poliphile*, 1499) by Francesco Colonna, the *Cinquième Livre* (1564) by François Rabelais, and the *Voyage des Princes fortunés* (1610) by Beroalde de Verville belong to a “literary esotericism” in some ways comparable to that of Andreae's Rosicrucian novel (1616; section II, 3). Mannerism and occult sciences got along harmoniously in the works of Maurice Scève (*Microcosme*, 1562), Guy Lefèvre de la Boderie (*La Gaillade*, 1578), Fabio Paolini (*Hebdomades*, 1589; section II, 2), Edmund Spencer (*The Fairie Queene*, 1596), Torquato Tasso (*Mondo creato*, 1607), and Giambattista Marino (*Dicerie Sacre*, 1614). Dramatists brought this same science onto the Elizabethan stage, whether their plays are permeated with it (William Shakespeare, *The Tempest*, 1610) or are concerned with mocking it (Ben Jonson, *The Alchemist*, 1610). But such works are countless, from the baroque and theosophical collection of poems *Cherubinischer Wandersmann* (1675) of Johann Scheffler (*alias* Angelus Silesius) to the explicitly alchemical theater of Christian Knorr von Rosenroth (*Conjugium Phoebis et Palladis*, 1677), and including the very popular *Comte de Gabalis ou entretiens sur les sciences secrètes* (1670) of Montfaucon de Villars.

The paintings of Jerome Bosch (“The Garden of Delights,” toward 1510) and of Peter Breughel the elder (*Dulle Griet*, 1562) have not yet revealed all their mysteries. Two pictorial works of the seventeenth century merit particular attention. One is the anonymous painting *La Vierge alchimique*, visible in the Saint-Rémy Museum of Reims, of Hermetist and arithmosophical connotations, a work probably

sponsored by the Jesuits and dating from the beginning of the seventeenth century. The other is the Kabbalistic altarpiece *Turris Antonia* (or “didactic tablet of the princess Antonia de Wurtemberg”), painted at Bad Teinach, near Stuttgart (1663–1673). Both are still located in their place of origin. The examples are many. For instance, one of the engravings of the *Icones Biblicae* of Matthieu Merian (reproduced in the Lutheran Bible of Strasbourg, 1623) represents the Wedding at Cana in a setting that seems to allude to both the Rosicrucian teachings and the alchemical transmutation.